indignant response: ‘You ought to be ashamed of yourself, Pan Vitkevitch . . . You talk of your mission as if it were some sacred feat . . . You, who did not hesitate to sacrifice your life, wealth, and position for the sake of freeing your dear motherland from slavery . . . you now assist with enslaving independent nations. You, who used to despise spies and traitors, have become one yourself . . .’ Tyshkevitch lectured his friend for some time. When he had finished, Vitkevitch collapsed, deflated and depressed: ‘A traitor, he whispered, yes, a traitor. God damn it all!’ As soon as Tyshkevitch left, seized with remorse, Vitkevitch had lit his fire, burned his papers and taken a pistol from the trunk on his hotel-room floor. This he put in his mouth, then pulled the trigger.[8]

The idea of a depression – or melancholia as the Victorians called it – provoked by shame and guilt being the cause of Vitkevitch’s suicide was also the explanation favoured by his travelling companion Ivan Blaramberg, who knew him well in his final months. ‘In April we received the sad news of our friend Vitkevitch’s suicide,’ Blaramberg later wrote in his memoirs.

> This was a tragic end for a young man who could yet have been of much use to our government for he had the energy, the enterprise, and all the necessary qualities to play in Asia the role of Alexander Burnes. During our journey to Persia and the sojourn there he was often in a melancholy mood and would say that he had had enough of life. Pointing at a breech-loading Bertran pistol, he once remarked: ‘Avec ce pistolet-là, je me brulerai un jour la cervelle.’ And he kept his word, as it was with this very pistol that he shot himself in a moment of deep melancholy.[9]

The suicide of Vitkevitch was only one of many far-reaching repercussions of Shah Shuja’s return to the throne of Afghanistan.

In Orenburg, Vitkevitch’s champion, Count Perovsky, was determined that Russia would not be outmanoeuvred by British machinations in Central Asia. As soon as it became clear that the British were about to invade Afghanistan, Perovsky began lobbying to revive Russian prestige in the region by conquering the Turkman Khanate of Khiva, something he had been pushing for since 1835. For many years the Khivans had been buying the kidnapped and enslaved Russian serfs abducted from the border region by the Kazakhs; the British advance into Central Asia gave Perovsky the excuse he had been waiting for to put his invasion plan into action. A committee assembled in St Petersburg to consider his proposal and decided that the expedition to Khiva should ‘consolidate the influence of Russia in